

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective July 1, 2026

Policy No. NE:01.0

Standards for Nutrition Education Contacts

Purpose

To ensure nutrition education (NE) is made available to all participants and addresses the nutritional needs of the participants.

Authority

7 CFR Part 246.11

Policy

WIC participants must be offered NE at no cost according to federal regulations and state policies.

Definitions

Nutrition Education – Individual or group sessions and the provision of materials designed to improve health status and achieve positive change in dietary and physical activity habits, and that emphasize the relationship between nutrition, physical activity, and health, all in keeping with the personal and cultural preferences of the individual.

Electronic Benefit Account (EBA) – The account where food benefits are being held for redemption.

In-Person Nutrition Education – When a participant completes NE in a setting where WIC staff is present.

Remote Nutrition Education – When a participant completes NE in a setting where WIC staff is not present.

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Procedures

- I. All women participants and parent/guardians/caretakers of infants and children must be offered an NE contact every three months.
- II. All NE contacts must:
 - A. Be provided by qualified staff (Policy [NE:02.0](#), [TR:03.0](#)).
 - B. Address participants' questions and concerns.
 - C. Be delivered using current client-centered learning principles.
 - D. Meet participant's language preference and be culturally sensitive.
 - E. Include professional assessment by WIC staff.
 - F. Contain evidence-based messaging.
 - G. Be documented in the management information system (MIS).
 - H. Be offered according to participant's interests, category, risk conditions, time considerations and preferred delivery method; participants may choose a preferred NE contact.
 - I. Include evaluation to ensure appropriateness and effectiveness (Policy [QA:01.0](#); [NE:02.0](#)).
- III. Substance abuse information must be provided to all pregnant, breastfeeding, and postpartum women and to parents/guardians/caretakers of infants and children at initial certification and on an as-needed basis (Policy [CR:01.0 \(eWIC\)](#)).
- IV. Breastfeeding information and support must be provided to all pregnant and breastfeeding participants (Policies [BF:01.0](#), [02.0](#), [03.0](#), and [04.0](#)).
- V. Types of NE contacts include:
 - A. Individual counseling
 - 1. Must be provided at initial certification, subsequent certification and mid-certification assessment and at the request of the participant. May be offered as an NE contact at any time, including as secondary or subsequent NE.

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2. May be conducted in person, by telephone or video.
3. Staff must:
 - a. attempt to establish rapport;
 - b. attempt to identify and explore parent's/guardian's/caretaker's concerns using active listening skills and open-ended questions; and
 - c. Use critical thinking skills to prioritize and deliver appropriate nutrition services that will provide value to the participant through collaborative guidance (such as tailored evidence-based education, anticipatory guidance and/or action steps), encouragement and, if appropriate, referrals.
4. Must include the completion of appropriate documentation within the MIS.
 - a. A personalized nutrition note should be provided as a follow-up to the client's appointment.
 - b. In rare instances where a nutrition note is not appropriate, staff must document a summary of the session in the MIS.
 - c. For high risk counseling documentation, refer to [CS:33.0](#).
- B. Secondary or subsequent NE contacts include:
 1. Group classes
 - a. Must be offered at least once per month per full-time local agency (LA) site. Classes may be offered in-person or live virtually.
 - b. May be in the form of discussion groups, breastfeeding support groups, lessons with activities and/or videos, or other client-centered methods such as garden-based classes, grocery tours, etc.
 - c. Must be presented by qualified staff, who have been trained on the subject matter prior to teaching the class and remain

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- present for the duration of the class (Policies: [NE:02.0](#); [TR:03.0](#)).
- i. Breastfeeding support groups must be led by an International Board Certified Lactation Consultant (IBCLC), a trained Peer Counselor (PC) or any Certifying Authority (CA) who has completed their required breastfeeding (BF) training (Policy [BF:04.0](#); [TR:03.0](#)).
 - d. Must be offered as indicated in the currently approved NE plan. ([NE:02.0](#)).
 - e. Must be a state agency (SA) or LA developed lesson plan (Policy [NE:04.0](#)).
 - f. Must allocate time for participants to ask questions related to the class topic. If the educator is unable to answer the question during the session, staff should follow up with the participant or refer them to an appropriate resource.
- 2. Self-paced lessons, including take home lessons
 - a. Must be SA or LA developed (Policy [NE:04.0](#));
 - b. May include videos, books or paper-based lessons;
 - c. Must be reviewed by a designated staff member with the participant;
 - 3. Health fairs
 - a. Must include an activity and evaluation.
 - b. Must contain content approved by an LA or SA Registered Dietitian (RD).
 - 4. TexasWIC.org lessons must be offered and accepted.
 - 5. Alternate forms of NE
 - a. Participants may receive WIC NE contacts from outside agencies or certain professional persons at the discretion of

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the LA NE coordinator and based on standards specified in Procedure II, with the approval of the SA NE Branch. Examples include but are not limited to: diabetes support groups, and nutrition counseling by an RD.

- b. For families of children with special health care needs, see Policy [CR:07.0 \(eWIC\)](#).

VI. Benefit Issuance

- A. In-person NE – when the participant is present in the clinic, upload benefits to the EBA at NE appointment and schedule the next appointment.
- B. Remote NE – when the participant is not present in the clinic, check if an NE contact was completed, upload benefits to the EBA and contact the participant to provide notification of the benefit issuance and the next appointment.
 - 1. TexasWIC.org class – check the MIS for class completion within the past three months.
 - 2. Virtual LA group class – follow LA procedures for verifying attendance.
 - 3. If class completion is not available, contact the participant.
 - a. If the participant states they have completed an NE contact, document it in the MIS. (Proof is not required.)
 - b. If the participant has not completed a NE contact, offer NE options.

VII. Nutrition education may be declined by participants.

- A. Food benefits must be issued to all participants, even those who decline NE.
- B. Participants unable to stay for an NE contact or who decline an NE contact must be issued food benefits as soon as possible. When a

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participant declines, refuses NE or is unable to receive NE due to an emergency, this must be documented in the MIS.

- VIII. Each LA is responsible for ensuring equipment and materials necessary to conduct NE classes or counseling are available at all clinic sites in accordance with the approved NE/BF Plan (Policies [AC:33.0](#); [AC:34.0](#); [NE:02.0](#)).
- IX. LA NE expenditures must be in accordance with Policies [AC:33.0](#) and [AC:34.0](#).